

## Application for **GLOCAL's** CanConnect Microgrant

### **Youth Digital Talent Empowerment** Final Project Submission

Max Du

I want to express my gratitude to **Glocal Foundation Canada** for this opportunity of applying for **CanConnect Grant** to support more youth in **Digital Civic engagement and Leadership**.

We take great pride in showcasing key project events and progress on our website. We sincerely appreciate your valuable time and consideration in reviewing them:

Website: [www.youthdigitaltalent.com](http://www.youthdigitaltalent.com)



**Youth Digital Talent** is the first nonprofit registered in Canada dedicated to empower and train youth ages 12-24 with digital skills, focus to support underrepresented **immigrant and refugee youth**, team up digital talent to develop digital solutions to help **nonprofits** for good, and **small businesses** for economic impact.

**Why do we support immigrant and refugee youth?**

#### **Background Story:**

Honoured judges, I am Max Du, a high school student from an immigrant family. In 2020, my mom lost her job due to the Covid-19 pandemic. To alleviate our financial hardship, I assisted her in establishing an online business profile. I then realized the potential of young people like me to aid people facing similar challenges. In 2022, I led a schoolwide survey and reaffirmed my vision, leading to the creation of Digital Talent Club that attracted over 50 members in three months. This year, I launched the Youth Digital Talent to scale up beyond school. I want to promote more immigrant and refugee youth like myself who are facing unique challenges of low-income and limited digital resources, to become digital talent - not only digital competent but also impactful to better our community.

#### **We apply for GLOCAL's CanConnect Micro Grant**

- **because Youth Digital Talent Empowerment project aligns with the goals of CANConnect and the GLOCAL Foundation** by bridging immigrant and refugee youth from digital divide with equitable access to civic engagement opportunities, and with **great significance** by empowering immigrant and refugee youth to become next-gen digital leaders in civic engagement and service in Canada.

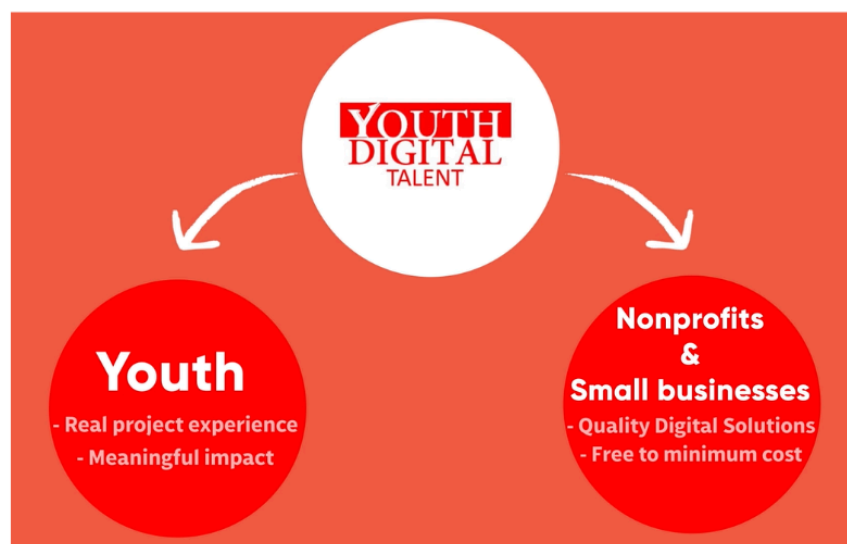
Youth Digital Talent Empowerment Program uniquely bridges the digital divide for immigrant and refugee youth with equitable access to civic engagement opportunities, by empowering them with digital skills and working out digital solutions to help nonprofits and small businesses in digital transformation. I would highly appreciate this cherished microgrants and put it into good use to promote a more inclusive and innovative community for digital civic leadership and service.

Hereunder are slides about our project details:



Youth Digital Talent Empowerment is an **innovative initiative** addressing the digital divide and **increase Digital Civic engagement and Leadership for youth**

- **Unique perspective - by youth and for youth. we bridge** the digital divide for **immigrant and refugee youth** with **equitable access** to civic engagement opportunities, by provides **customized digital skills training** to meet their learning levels and preferences
  - **Unique framework** - Provide **unlikely venue to improving the career pathways** of immigrant and refugee youth disconnected from career opportunities to work out digital solutions to **help nonprofits and small businesses** in digital transformation
  - **Unique approach to youth engagement** - **teaming up not-ready-yet students** in our inclusive project teams with enhanced peer to peer learning and mentoring, and **provides stipend** to knock down financial barriers
- ★ **National Ingenious+ Innovation Award**  
Youth Digital Talent won 2023 national Ingenious+ Innovation Award Regional Winner for demonstrating creativity and problem solving skills by developing innovative solutions to real world problems.





## Project Team Roles

Developer  
Designer  
Project Manager

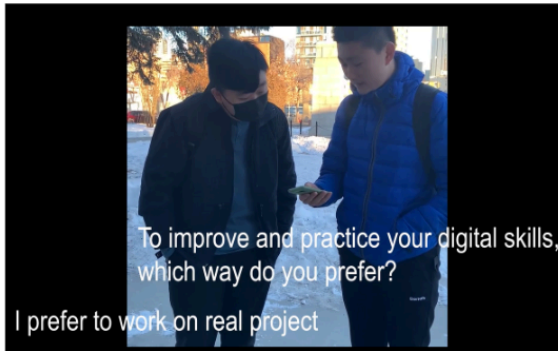


Youth Digital Talent Empowerment has been built through  
**immense research**

- **Peer feedback**
- **Schoolwide survey**
- **Expert thoughts** - I attended Calgary Youth Employment Centre workshop hosted by Leita Blassett
- I followed **education institutes** like SAIT Digital Transformation Bootcamps
- I checked **federal policies**, such as Youth Employment and Skills Strategy (YESS)
- I did **extensive online research** about digital skills demand and youth employment, my research doc 86 pages



## Schoolwide Student Survey



## Challenge #1

### Youth demand for upskilling and hands-on work opportunities

All students think they need to **upskill digital skills**,  
but current CBE **curriculum** does not provide these hands-on learning opportunities

80% students want to **join a team** using digital skills to **help a small business**  
or a non profit organization

but 88% students felt **hard to find** a part time/summer job that **uses digital skills**

Youth **unemployment** rate is **twice** the national average

**??? immigrant and refugee youth**



Youth Digital Talent Empowerment is **a practical, useful, effective** civic engagement initiative to increase equity of digital learning access for youth

- Training youth with **practical** hands-on digital skills beginning at early ages, which is different from conventional classroom and online course learning
- Learning while working on **real world** digital projects - this innovative approach is proven by YDT students as the most efficient and engaging for learning outcomes, while making meaningful impact
- **Effectively** lower the barrier to both accessing digital skills learning and starting real projects for those not-ready-yet or less confident youth by teaming them up
- Outreach youth at underserved communities, empower these groups of youth with more **tailored supports** such as providing digital tools to those who may not have access at home, and stipend reducing financial barriers
- Build **down to earth supportive** YDT **Mentors Community** to guidance youth cracking clients digital projects, grow more **mentors from underrepresented community as role models** to inspire and motivate more youth from similar backgrounds



### Free Digital Skills Training



**New!** - Immigrant and refugee students get stipends for their part time work to alleviate family financial burden while making community contributions



Youth Digital Talent Empowerment has progressed with **great social and economic impact** so far

The project is proudly presented on our website:  
[WWW.YOUTHDIGITALTALENT.COM](http://WWW.YOUTHDIGITALTALENT.COM)

**Our students are mostly from immigrant families. We have YDT project teams delivered 3 creative digital solutions**

- 1 project for a public education institute. The informative website and interactive virtual 3D model of the real reconciliation garden will be used as the official online host space, media networking and digital education tool for thousands CBE students, families and public audience
- 1 project for a small business. The App prototype will be used as part of the app-based TruDiary Tribe community networking function, solve a challenge a startup business faces by creating a innovative real digital solution that has lasting impact to better lives of black and brown moms in under-resourced communities
- 1 project for a nonprofit organization. The website has been used successfully in spreading the word of Step in Stem organization all over the world and acquiring many new branches to reach many more students

**Empowered 125 high school students with digital skills learning**

- through hands-on mentoring on client project, industrial business office tour, guest speaker, virtual meetup, webinar, etc.

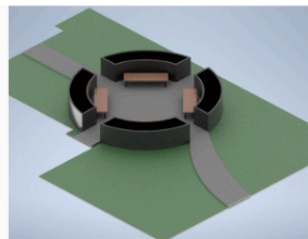


**Our students are mostly from immigrant families. We have YDT project teams delivered 3 creative digital solutions**

#### **Reconciliation Garden Digital Development Project**

**Website Development Team:** Max Du, Weston Wang, Matthew Hu, Anavi Jain, Theola Ma, Jessie Zou, Nykin Leskiw, Bryan Zhu, James Wang, Sean Lee

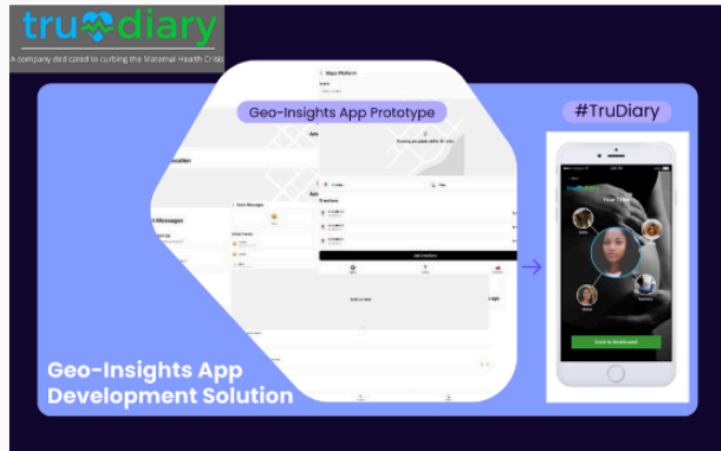
**3D Modelling Team:** Matthew Hu, Max Du, Patrick Li, Nykin Leskiw, Sean Lee





## Geo-Insights App Development Solution for TruDiary

**Team Members:** Max Du, Jeffery Moon, Zoey Jiang



### Project Brief:

This project was for TruDiary, a digital health company dedicated to helping black and brown moms in under-resourced communities obtain quality Prenatal and Postpartum Care and Social Determinants of Health (SDOH) services.

## Website Development for Step in STEM

**Team Members:** Mickael Naouri



## Collaboration with Neo Financial

**Business Tour @ Neo Financial**

**- Meeting UX, Product & Development Teams**



**We earned great support from Neo Financial to help us learn UX/UI Design with Guest Speaker Ivy Damian**



**How you can interact in the metaverse meetings Instead of zooming meetings?**



## Virtual keynote Speaker Meetup

**Join Cullen Jennings, CTO Security and Collaboration, Cisco, for a deep dive into these technologies, taking away a new understanding of how humans interact in the metaverse**





## Upcoming Digital Skills Training Workshop



- Youth Digital Talent is holding **Building a Personal Website: Intro to Applying UI/UX Design Workshop** on Dec 30, 2023
- YDT is partnering with **Portal Immigrant Association (PIA)**, The first Francophone youth center in Alberta based in Calgary, to empower **immigrant youth @ PIA** with a **Website Dev workshop** on Jan 26, 2024
- YDT is meeting with **The Youth Hub team at CCIS (Calgary Catholic Immigration Society)** for possible collaboration on **digital skills training** on Jan 5, 2023



Youth Digital Talent Empowerment building and running was so **difficult** for me...

### 1. Getting Funding

Facing economic limitations, I have been working hard to learn how to and actioned quick to outreach any possible fundings, grants and sponsorships. For example, I gained support from Sprout Ideas Fellowship to help with website costs etc.

### 2. Source Partnerships and Mentors

As we have just launched, we didn't have any established credit. To gain support, I have maken dozens of cold calls/cold emails to outreach any possible orgs and experts.

### 3. Starting, organizing, and leading a team

Building my exec team from scratch was difficult as well. Same as any startup, I needed to find team members who were passionate, hard-working, and leaders. I now lead a team of 6 executives, 3 directors across the world in the US and France.

### 4. Time crunch

As a high school student in the most intensive IB program, I had to start early to reply to emails before school and organized events after school and weekends. Although it is quite challenging, I managed to be time-efficient.



Thank you **GLOCAL** Foundation of Canada



### Conclusion:

Youth Digital Talent Empowerment Program uniquely addresses the digital divide from a youth perspective. It not only addresses the disparity in access to digital resources but also gives special focus on immigrant and refugee students, to promote their digital civic engagement and empower them with digital skills and competence. This program positively bridges the digital skills gap through preparing immigrant and refugee youth to be future digital leaders and community contributors significantly accelerating digital transformation for nonprofits and small businesses. In essence, this program bridging the digital divide while fostering a digitally inclusive and innovative society.

At last, I would like to express my gratitude to **Glocal Foundation Canada** for this opportunity of applying for CanConnect Grant.

I would highly appreciate this cherished microgrants and put it into good use to promote a more inclusive and innovative community for digital civic leadership and service.